Parshas Vayeira

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The Lamplighter

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Parsha Insights

The Miracle of a Child

By Rabbi Jonathan Sacks

There is a mystery at the heart of Jewish existence, engraved into the first syllables of our recorded time.

The first words of G-d to Abraham were: "Go out from your land, your birthplace, and your father's house . . . And I will make you a great nation. . ."

In the next chapter there is another promise: "I will make your children like the dust of the earth, so that if anyone could count the dust of the earth, so shall your offspring be counted."

Two chapters later comes a third: "G-d took him outside and said, 'Look at the heavens and count the stars – if indeed you can count them.' Then He said to him, 'So shall your children be.'"

Finally, the fourth: "Your name will be Abraham, for I have made you a father of many nations."



Four escalating promises: Abraham would be the father of a great nation, as many as the dust of the earth and the stars of the sky. He would be the father not of one nation but of many.

What, though, was the reality? Early in the story, we read that Abraham was "very wealthy in livestock and in silver and gold." He had everything except one thing – a child. Then G-d appeared to Abraham and said, "Your reward will be very great."

Until now, Abraham has been silent. Now, something within him breaks, and he asks: "O L-rd G-d, what will you give me if I remain childless?" The first recorded words of Abraham to G-d are a plea for there to be future generations. The first Jew feared he would be the last.

Then a child is born. Sarah gives Abraham her handmaid Hagar, hoping that she will give him a child. She gives birth to a son whose name is Ishmael, meaning "G-d has heard." Abraham's prayer has been answered, or so we think. But in the next chapter, that hope is destroyed. Yes, says G-d, Ishmael will be blessed. He will be the father of twelve princes and a great nation. But he is not the child of Jewish destiny, and one day Abraham will have to part from him.

This pains Abraham deeply. He pleads: "If only Ishmael might live under Your blessing." Later, when Sarah drives Ishmael away, we read that "This distressed Abraham greatly because it concerned his son." Nonetheless, the decree remains.

G-d insists that Abraham will have a son by Sarah. Both laugh. How can it be? They are old. Sarah is post- menopausal. Yet against possibility, the son is born. His name is Isaac, meaning "laughter":

"Sarah said, 'G-d has brought me laughter, and everyone who hears about this will laugh with me." And she added, "Who would have said to Abraham that Sarah would nurse children? Yet I have borne him a son in his old age.'"

Finally, the story seems to have a happy ending. After all the promises and prayers, Abraham and Sarah at last have a child. Then come the words which, in all the intervening centuries, have not lost their power to shock:

"After these things, G-d tested Abraham. He said to him, 'Abraham!' 'Here I am,' he replied. Then G-d said, 'Take your son, your only son, Isaac, whom you love, and go to the region of Moriah. Sacrifice him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains that I will show you.'"

Abraham takes his son, travels for three days, climbs the mountain, prepares the wood, ties his son, takes the knife and raises his hand. Then a voice is heard from heaven: "Do not lay a hand on the boy." The trial is over. Isaac lives.

Why all the promises and disappointments? Why the hope so often raised, so often unfulfilled? Why delay? Why Ishmael? Why the binding? Why put Abraham and Sarah through the agony of thinking that the son for whom they have waited for so long is about to die?

There are many answers in our tradition, but one transcends all others. We cherish what we wait for and what we most risk losing. Life is full of wonders. The birth of a child is a miracle. Yet,

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What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

Candle Lighting Times

Greater Toronto Area

Light Candles	5:53 PM
Shabbos Ends	6:53 PM

Parsha in a Nutshell

Parshas Vayeira

The name of the Parshah, "Vayeira," means "And He appeared" and it is found in Genesis 18:1.

G-d reveals Himself to Abraham three days after the first Jew's circumcision at age ninety-nine; but Abraham rushes off to prepare a meal for three guests who appear in the desert heat. One of the three—who are angels disguised as men—announces that, in exactly one year, the barren Sarah will give birth to a son. Sarah laughs.

Abraham pleads with G-d to spare the wicked city of Sodom. Two of the three disguised angels arrive in the doomed city, where Abraham's nephew Lot extends his hospitality to them and protects them from the evil intentions of a Sodomite mob. The two guests reveal that they have come to overturn the place, and to save Lot and his family. Lot's wife turns into a pillar of salt when she disobeys the command not to look back at the burning city as they flee.

While taking shelter in a cave, Lot's two daughters (believing that they and their father are the only ones left alive in the world) get their father drunk, lie with him and become pregnant. The two sons born from this incident father the nations of Moab and Ammon.

Abraham moves to Gerar, where the Philistine king Abimelech takes Sarah—who is presented as Abraham's sister—to his palace. In a dream, G-d warns Abimelech that he will die unless he returns the woman to her husband. Abraham explains that he feared he would be killed over the beautiful Sarah.

G-d remembers His promise to Sarah, and gives her and Abraham a son, who is named Isaac (Yitzchak, meaning "will laugh"). Isaac is circumcised at the age of eight days; Abraham is one hundred years old, and Sarah ninety, at their child's birth.

Hagar and Ishmael are banished from Abraham's home and wander in the desert; G-d hears the cry of the dying lad, and saves his life by showing his mother a well. Abimelech makes a treaty with Abraham at Beersheba, where Abraham gives him seven sheep as a sign of their truce.

G-d tests Abraham's devotion by commanding him to sacrifice Isaac on Mount Moriah (the Temple Mount) in Jerusalem. Isaac is bound and placed on the altar, and Abraham raises the knife to slaughter his son. A voice from heaven calls to stop him; a ram, caught in the undergrowth by its horns, is offered in Isaac's place.

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precisely because these things are natural, we take them for granted, forgetting that nature has an architect, and history an author.

Judaism is a sustained discipline in not taking life for granted. We were the people born in slavery so that we would value freedom. We were the nation always small, so that we would know that strength does not lie in numbers but in the faith that begets courage. Our ancestors walked through the valley of the shadow of death, so that we could never forget the sanctity of life.

Throughout history, Jews were called on to value children. Our entire value system is built on it. Our citadels are schools, our passion, education, and our greatest heroes, teachers. The seder service on Pesach can only begin with questions asked by a child. On the first day of the New Year, we read not about the creation of the universe but about the birth of a child – Isaac to Sarah, Samuel to Hannah. Ours is a supremely child-centered faith.

That is why, at the dawn of Jewish time, G-d put Abraham and Sarah through these trials – the long wait, the unmet hope, the binding itself – so that neither they nor their descendants would ever take children for granted. Every child is a miracle. Being a parent is the closest we get to G-d – bringing life into being through an act of love.

Today, when too many children live in poverty and illiteracy, dying for lack of medical attention because those who rule nations are focused on fighting the battles of the past rather than shaping a safe future, it is a lesson the world has not yet learned. For the sake of humanity it must, for the tragedy is vast and the hour is late.

Jewish Matters

The Rebbe Rashab's Birthday

There's a story the Lubavitcher Rebbe liked to tell about a five-year-old child and a 99-year-old man. The 99-year-old man lived 36 centuries earlier; his name was Abraham, the first Jew.

On his fourth or fifth birthday, Rabbi Sholom DovBer visited his grandfather, Rabbi Menachem Mendel of Lubavitch, and burst into tears. His teacher in cheder had taught them that week's Torah reading, Vayeira, which begins, "And G-d revealed Himself to Abraham..." Why, wept the child, doesn't G-d reveal Himself to me?

Rabbi Menachem Mendel replied: "When a Jew, a tzaddik, realizes at the age of 99 that he must circumcise himself, that he must continue to perfect himself, he is worthy that G-d should reveal Himself to him."

The child was Rabbi Sholom DovBer Schneersohn, the fifth Lubavitcher Rebbe, known as the Rebbe Rashab. Born on the 20th of Cheshvan 5621 (1860), his birthday falls this Shabbos.

After his father's passing in 1882, he assumed leadership of the movement. Over the next 38 years, he delivered some 2,000 maamarim (Chassidic discourses), including the famed hemshechim, containing his profound analytical treatment of Chabad Chassidism.

In 1897, he established the Tomchei Temimim yeshivah in Lubavitch, integrating the "body" (Talmudic and legal studies) and "soul" (philosophic and mystical) of Torah. Its students would later give their lives to keep Judaism alive under Soviet rule.

In 1915, he fled Lubavitch because of WWI and settled in Rostov-on-Don. There, he began the struggle against Communist efforts to destroy the Jewish faith, continued by his son and successor, Rabbi Yosef Yitzchak Schneersohn.

He passed away in Rostov in 1920.

Food For Thought

We are more than believers. We are believers in believing.

We know the power of holding to one's convictions and have perfect faith it will succeed.

Your thoughts on the Lamplighter matter!
Tell us what you like and how we can improve it.

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

Encouragement on the Campaign Trail

By Valerie Shore

My Story - with the - Rebbe



In 1989, my husband Scott decided to run for U.S. Congress on the Republican ticket. This meant challenging the incumbent Democrat, Congressman Harry Johnston, in Florida's 14th district which, includes Boca Raton, where we were living at the time.

When our Lubavitcher friend, Rabbi Yossi Biston, heard about this plan, he immediately advised my husband to seek the Rebbe's guidance and blessing. Although we were not Lubavitch ourselves, we were deeply connected to Chabad, and so we decided to follow Rabbi Biston's advice.

On March 27, 1989, we travelled together to New York in order to meet the Rebbe. When it was our turn, Scott told the Rebbe, "I am considering running for United States Congress, and I would like to know whether or not it is proper for a Shabbat-observant Jew to do so."

The Rebbe answered, "Not only is it proper, in many ways it is a sanctification of G-d's name. If you are in Congress and everyone knows that you observe Shabbat, those gentiles who respect the Noahide Laws will be inspired to be more observant as well."

As soon as we returned to Florida, my husband moved forward with the campaign, and he received the Republican nomination virtually without opposition. But then came the hard part. We were young and naïve and did not realize the amount of money that would be necessary to keep the campaign afloat. We had to hire expensive political advisors, and we took out substantial loans to pay for them. After a while, we began to question if we could raise enough money to make it till the end.

In addition to the fundraising problems, we were also facing nasty and libelous attacks in the press due to Scott's opposition to abortion on demand. Almost every day there was another terrible comment about him. It was not a positive experience at all, and we were debating whether or not we should continue.

So again, we decided to seek the Rebbe's advice. With the help of the local Chabad emissaries, we sent a fax to the Rebbe, but received no reply.

Then one day my husband flew three famous pollsters down from New York for a dinner meeting at our home. During the dinner, the phone rang. Now, Scott never answers the phone, but for some reason – while in the middle of this important meeting – he excused himself and picked up. It was Rabbi Leibel Groner, the Rebbe's secretary, who conveyed the following message: "The Rebbe feels that if there will be financial strain and emotional distress involved, then it is not worth it for you to continue the campaign."

Thinking back, it was just incredible that he called exactly at that time. The only problem was that now we were too deep into it to back out. We pressed on, even though we shouldn't have.

One good thing that happened during the campaign was that Scott really got a chance to assert his religious ideals. There came a time when President George H. Bush –came down to Florida and a photo-op was arranged. But because it was Shabbat, Scott said, "No thanks. I can't do it." It could have helped him a lot, but he just wouldn't violate Shabbat.

Many religious Jews go through life saying that Shabbat is more important to them than the President of the United States, but my husband actually got to prove it. So that was one positive highlight.

Other than that though, it was horrible. Scott won only one third of the vote and lost in a landslide to Congressman Johnston. As a result, he became despondent. He had viewed politics as a means of instituting lofty ideas, so the reality was greatly disillusioning to him. It was a very difficult time for all of us.

In order to improve his mood, we got the kids out of school and took a trip to visit his parents in the Berkshires. We thought that getting away from everything would help, but it didn't. Scott was just too depressed – he had lost a lot of money and he didn't even have a job to go back to. He also felt very alone – during the campaign he was constantly receiving visits and phone calls; after he lost, there was nothing.

It seemed hopeless, until one day, out of the blue, the phone rang. It was Rabbi Groner again. I watched my husband as he held the phone to his ear and, suddenly, I saw his entire demeanor change.

Rabbi Groner called to convey another message from the Rebbe: "Be happy. It was a good thing that you ran. And, because of it, you will have many more opportunities in the future to make contributions to the Jewish people."

We were stunned. We did not have any specific connection with the Rebbe to speak of. I have no idea how the Rebbe knew we were in a rut. We had not spoken to his emissaries after the campaign. Yet, somehow, he knew.

The thought that the Rebbe cared about Scott – whom he had met only once and called him to see how he is doing – energized him. From that point on, Scott's entire viewpoint changed and his entire way of thinking changed from negative to positive. It was incredible.

And, in the end, all turned out well. Scott was hired by the Bush administration and served in several high profile positions, including working on Israel's Arrow missile defense project.

It's been more than twenty years now, and I am still grateful and amazed how the Rebbe knew to do just the right thing at just the right time to help a fellow Jew.

Mrs. Valerie Shore presently teaches in the Ganeynu program at the Jewish Community Center of West Palm Beach. She was interviewed in Chabad of Boca Raton in March of 2011.

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Who Put That Old Person in My Mirror?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

Question:

I'm at a stage in my life where nothing's wrong but I'm not handling it. I've hit fifty, my parents are getting older, and I've got less patience. I haven't fulfilled the dreams I thought I would reach by now, and I'm not settled in myself. Is this normal? What do I do to get through this? It's starting to really get me down.

Response:

Yes, it's normal. Getting older brings challenges that can catch us by surprise. Everyone faces them in different ways, and you can't avoid them. But you don't have to face them on your own. It's good that you reached out, and don't hesitate to seek professional help from a therapist.

What I can offer you is a formula from the Baal Shem Tov for dealing with just about everything that comes your way. It's a three-step process: Acceptance, Separation and Sweetening.

Let's take your situation. You're not as young as you used to be. Neither are your parents. You don't have the energy, stamina, and light-heartedness you had twenty years ago. It's frustrating.

Let's apply the three steps.

First comes Acceptance. Accept that you are getting older. This is where you are. You can't fight reality. You can't reverse it. You can't go back in time. You can't switch lives with somebody else.

You are who you are, where you are, right here, right now. You don't call the shots, G-d does. Accept it. That doesn't mean giving up. It means starting from where you are. Until you accept that, we can't move on.

Once you've accepted reality as it is, you need to shift your perspective on it. This is the second step: Separation. Separate the facts of your life from the story you're telling yourself about them. Drop your assumptions. You have defined getting older as a bad thing. Separate from that definition and see it for what it is: entering your next stage. You aren't falling, you are progressing.

That sets up the final step: Sweetening. Turn what seemed negative into a positive. The things going on in your life, even if they seem like obstacles, can become stepping stones. Getting older means engaging in life on a more mature level, experiencing things more deeply, appreciating what you once overlooked. You may not have achieved everything you dreamed of, but perhaps there are new dreams you never even thought of.

You are being invited to go deeper into life, to embrace a new level, to take a step up. Difficulties are not just interruptions to life, they can be invitations to growth. Don't avoid the challenge. Take it on, bring it in, let it transform you. Make the bitter sweet. You need all three steps: acceptance, separation, sweetening. You can't jump to sweetening without accepting where you're at and reframing it. Each step takes time and work.

But it's worth it. Here's the message for someone hitting fifty: you're not getting older. You're getting sweeter.

Living Moshiach

"Abraham called the name of his son . . . Yitzchak." (Vayeira 21:3)

The Talmud (Shabbat 89b) states that in the Messianic age it is specifically of Yitzchak (Isaac) that we shall say "for you are our father" (Isaiah 63:16). Chassidut explains that the name Yitzchak is an expression of laughter and delight: in the Messianic age, the supernal joy and delight caused by our present service of G-d will be revealed.

Chassidut explains further that the patriarch Isaac represents the aspect of fear and awe of G-d, and the consequent self-negation before G-d. It is, therefore, specifically Isaac who relates to the future era, for at that time G-dliness will manifest itself in the world, and all creatures will be moved to a sense of self-negation.

Indeed, Isaac's life reflected certain qualities of the Messianic era. The Zohar (I: 60a) notes: when Abraham was about to sacrifice his son (Vayeira ch. 22), Isaac's soul departed from his body and was replaced by a soul from the "world to come." By virtue of this new soul, related to the era of redemption, Isaac's life was in the mode of the future era of the redemption.

Mitzvah Minute

The Torah scroll is a tangible embodiment of our connection to G-d, our most precious treasure and our guide to life. Really, every Jew should have one. "And now," Moses says, "write for yourselves this song" (Deuteronomy 31:19). Meaning that every Jew should write a Torah scroll.

But writing a Torah is a laborious process. Each one of its 304,805 letters must be written by hand, with ink and quill on parchment, in special calligraphy, by a trained scribe.

If you're not a trained scribe, you could always commission one to write a Torah for you. But if you can't afford that, there is another way to fulfill the mitzvah: Purchase just one letter in a Torah—meaning, have just one letter written specifically for you.

The Lamplighter

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This publication contains words from sacred literature. Please treat it with respect and do not deface or discard.

The Lamplighter is inspired by the works of the Lubavitcher Rebbe.

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